



Centurion

The Centurion is one of the classic postwar tanks. It started life as a heavy cruiser tank designed to take the highly effective 17-pounder gun used in World War II. By 1947 the gun's makers, the Royal Ordnance Factory, had designed a new weapon, the 20-pounder. This was capable of much better performance, and was adopted for a new Centurion model, the Mark 3, which also featured an improved version of the Rolls-Royce Meteor engine.

PRODUCTION BEGAN in 1945 at the Royal Ordnance Factory near Leeds, and the Vickers-Armstrong plant at Newcastle-upon-Tyne in the north of England; around 2,800 Mark 3 tanks were completed by 1956. In 1959, the 20-pounder guns were again replaced with the Royal Ordnance Factories' new L7 105 mm gun. This main gun fired a range of ammunition types, including Armor Piercing Discarding Sabot (APDS), Armor Piercing Fin Stabilized Discarding Sabot (APFSDS), and High Explosive Squash Head (HESH) rounds.

The Centurion's combat history began in the Korean War in 1950, where one regiment of Centurions was deployed with great success. The tank also saw action in Vietnam, the India-Pakistan conflict of 1965, and a number of Middle East conflicts.

Many features remained consistent throughout the tank's variants, including the welded, boat-shaped hull, Horstmann suspension, and Meteor engine. The latter was regarded as underpowered, limiting the tank's speed and agility, and it had a short operational range. In British service, the Centurion ran until the Mark 13—the version shown here—but other countries continued to improve their models until 2003.



REAR VIEW



SPECIFICATIONS

Name	Centurion Mark 13 FV4017
Date	1945-62
Origin	UK
Production	More than 13,750
Engine	Rolls Royce Meteor Mark 4B gasoline, 650 hp
Weight	58 tons (52.6 tonnes)
Main armament	105 mm L7A2
Secondary armament	.30 Browning M1919, .50 Browning M2
Crew	4
Armor thickness	6 in (152 mm) max

